

# **EVOLUTIONARY DISCOVERY OF REINFORCEMENT LEARNING ALGORITHMS VIA LARGE LANGUAGE MODELS**

Syggkounas, Loutfi & Persson — GECCO 2026

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# WHAT RL IS USED FOR

## Reasoning LLMs

o1, DeepSeek-R1 — RL makes them think

## LLM alignment

RLHF, DPO, GRPO, Constitutional AI

## Robotics & autonomy

$\pi_0$ , OpenVLA, Atlas, Waymo, AlphaStar

## Science & operations

AlphaDev, AlphaTensor, chip design, data-center cooling

This paper targets control RL — Gymnasium / MuJoCo; not LLM-RL.

# RL VS. ES AT A GLANCE

## Reinforcement Learning

Learn a policy by trial & error, updated with gradients on a scalar reward.

Where it runs today

- AlphaGo, AlphaStar, MuZero
- ChatGPT / Claude / Gemini (RLHF)
- o1, DeepSeek-R1 reasoning
- Humanoid locomotion, manipulation

The dominant paradigm.

## Evolutionary Search

Maintain a population, mutate & recombine, keep the fittest. No gradients.

Where it runs today

- Neural architecture search (NAS)
- Hyperparameter tuning (PBT, PB2)
- Reward discovery (Eureka, REvolve)
- Non-differentiable problems (Fun-Search)

The niche tool — used where RL can't go.

# THE PROBLEM WITH RL

The same handful of template families keeps getting recycled. LLM alignment has DPO / GRPO / ORPO / SimPO / KTO, but those are all preference-weighted PG. For control RL (this paper's domain), DQN '15, PPO '17, SAC '18, TD3 '18 are still the workhorses.

## Sample efficiency

- PPO / SAC:  $10^6$ – $10^7$  env steps on MuJoCo
- Humans:  $\sim 10^2$  steps

## Reproducibility

- $3\times$  return swings from seeds & HPs
- PPO impls disagree across codebases

## Fragility

- Reward hacking, credit-assignment drift
- Deadly triad: bootstrap + FA + off-policy

## Human bottleneck

- New algorithm = 1–2 yrs of PhD work
- The update rule has never been automated

# THE PROBLEM WITH ES

ES is powerful but boxed in by the designer — flexible and parallel, yet stuck with the search space you wrote down.

## Sample cost

- 3–10× more env steps than A3C / PPO
- No gradient, no bootstrap, no TD reuse

## Dimensionality

- Stalls past  $\sim 10^6$  parameters
- RL scales to billions of params

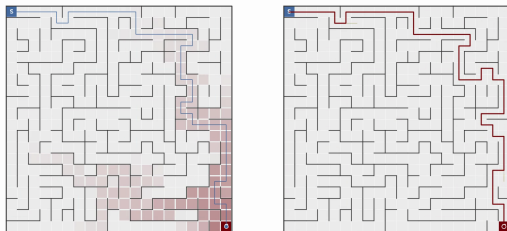
## Search space

- DSL / primitives are hand-designed
- Cannot express what you didn't foresee

## Blind mutations

- Random perturbations waste evals
- No semantic guidance on what to change

# DEMO --- WHEN RL WINS

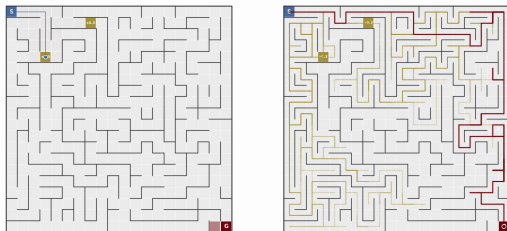


Same  $20 \times 20$  maze, sparse goal reward.

- RL: 212K env steps,  $\sim 50$ -step path
- ES:  **$24\times$  more env steps** for the same result

Clean credit assignment is RL's home turf.

# DEMO --- WHEN ES WINS



Add two small “trap” rewards near the start.

- RL: **0 / 2,000** episodes reach the big goal
- ES (MAP-Elites): **248 / 1,000** generations do
- 302 total breakthroughs · first at gen 44

Deceptive landscapes are where population search wins.

# WHAT THIS PAPER IS

- Evolutionary Discovery of RL Algorithms via LLMs Sygkounas, Loutfi & Persson — GECCO 2026
- Each candidate is an executable Python `compute_loss` function
- An LLM proposes mutations and crossovers over that code
- Each variant is scored by actually training agents in Gymnasium
- Extends REvolve — aimed at the **loss function**, not the reward
- Prompt bans actor-critic, value functions, and Bellman updates
- Discovers two new algorithms — CG-FPD and DF-CWP-CP
- Competitive with PPO and SAC across 10 Gymnasium benchmarks



# THE CANONICAL RL ALGORITHMS

- DQN (2015) — value-based, discrete action spaces
- TRPO (2015) — trust-region policy gradient
- DDPG (2015) — off-policy continuous control
- PPO (2017) — clipped policy gradient, the workhorse
- SAC (2018) — entropy-regularized off-policy
- TD3 (2018) — twin-critic DDPG

Every modern control-RL system runs on one of these.

Nothing genuinely new has been added in  $\sim 7$  years.

# AUTOML CLIMBS THE LADDER

| The update rule itself |                                                                                   | ???             |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------|
| Preference loss        |  | DiscoPOP        |
| Reward function        |                                                                                   | Eureka, REvolve |
| Hyperparameters        |                                                                                   | PB2, OptFormer  |
| Architecture           |                                                                                   | NAS, AmoebaNet  |

The **loss function** was the last frontier.

# **BACKGROUND**

Two lineages converge on one idea

# LINEAGE A: DISCOVER AN RL ALGORITHM

EPG '18

neural loss for PG

LPG '20

LSTM update rule

Co-Reyes '21

DAG over typed ops

DiscoRL '25

meta-learned  
NN (Nature)

All constrain the search space by hand.

# LINEAGE B: LLMS MUTATE CODE

ELM '22

LLMs as mutators

FunSearch '24

cap-set, bin-packing

AlphaEvolve '25

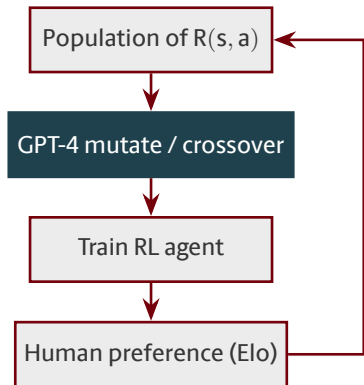
full files,  
Strassen beaten

EvoTune '25

proposer fine-tuning

LLMs are **intelligent variation operators** over code.

# PARENT WORK: REVOLVE (2024)



What REvolve evolves

- Executable Python **reward functions**
- Island populations, LLM variation
- Tested on driving, humanoid, dexterous hands

The move in this paper.  
Evolve the **loss function** instead of the reward.

# THE GAP THIS PAPER FILLS

| What gets evolved                            |   | Representative method  |
|----------------------------------------------|---|------------------------|
| Architecture                                 | ✓ | NAS, AmoebaNet         |
| Hyperparameters                              | ✓ | PB2, OptFormer         |
| Reward function                              | ✓ | REvolve, Eureka        |
| Preference loss (align)                      | ✓ | DiscoPOP               |
| Update rule (DAG)                            | ✓ | Co-Reyes 2021          |
| Update rule (black-box NN)                   | ✓ | LPG, DiscoRL           |
| Update rule (executable Python, LLM-evolved) | ★ | Sygekounas et al. 2026 |

Everything above is context. The bottom row is **the thesis**.

# **METHOD**

How the framework works



# THE BIG PICTURE

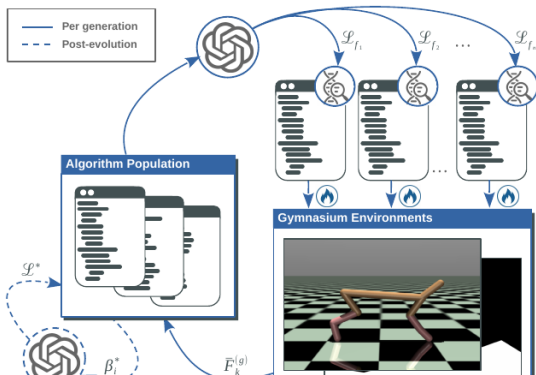


Figure 1 from the paper.

## Per generation

- LLM proposes candidate loss functions
- Each is trained end-to-end on 5 Gym envs
- Fitness drives selection

## Post-evolution

- LLM proposes hyperparameter ranges
- Sweep finds the refined rule  $\mathcal{L}^*$

# A CANDIDATE IS A CHUNK OF PYTHON

## Parent

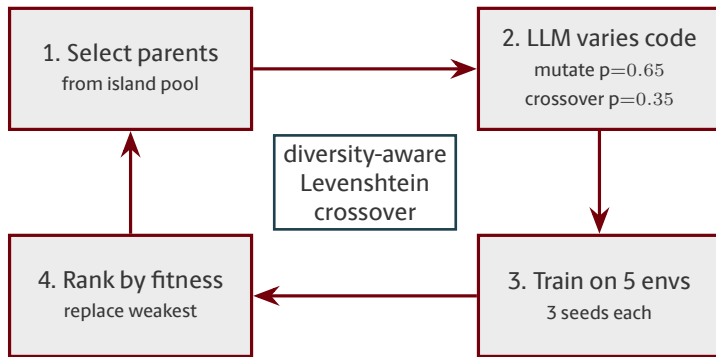
```
def compute_loss(theta, xi, D):  
    preds = model(D.s, theta)  
    targets = rollout(model, D.s)  
    L = mse(preds, targets)  
    return L
```

## After LLM mutation

```
def compute_loss(theta, xi, D):  
    preds = model(D.s, theta)  
    conf = xi.confidence(D.s)  
    targets = rollout(model, D.s)  
    L = (conf * mse(preds, targets)).mean()  
    return L
```

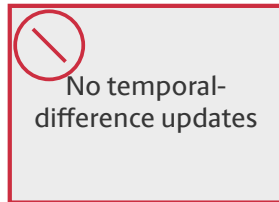
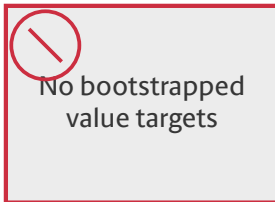
The LLM **edits Python**. That is the entire search space.

# THE EVOLUTIONARY LOOP



Island model · 9 individuals per island · 24 new candidates per generation.

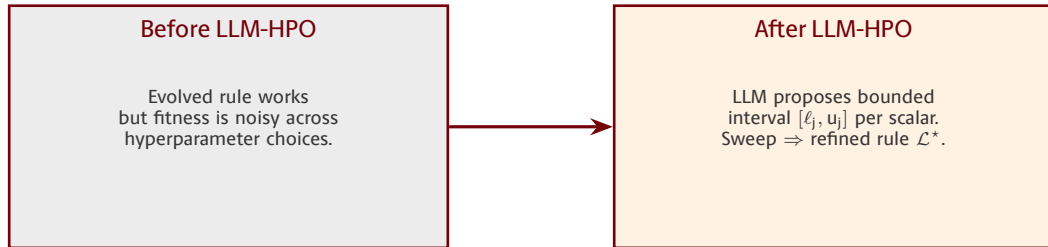
# WHAT THE LLM IS TOLD NOT TO DO



Constitutional prompt constraints  $\Rightarrow$  **forces novel mechanisms.**

Evolution cannot re-invent DQN; it has to find something else.

# LLM-GUIDED HPO PASS



Policy arch, optimizer, rollout loop stay frozen. Only internal scalars move.

# RESULTS

What evolution discovered

# THE TWO ALGORITHMS IT INVENTED

## CG-FPD

Confidence-Guided Forward Policy Distillation

Distill short-horizon plans from a learned latent dynamics model. Planning acts as the supervised teacher signal.

No value function. No policy gradient. No Bellman.

## DF-CWP-CP

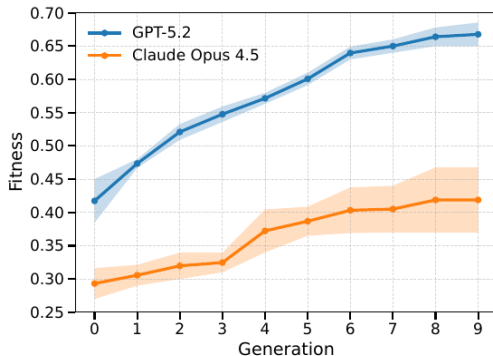
Differentiable Forward Confidence-Weighted Planning with Controllability Prior

Differentiable world-model rollouts + confidence-weighted desirability + controllability prior.

Also avoids every canonical RL mechanism.

Evolution rediscovered **model-based planning** — from scratch.

# THE PROPOSER LLM MATTERS. A LOT.



- GPT-5.2 climbs to **0.67**
- Claude 4.5 Opus caps at **0.42**
- Both monotone; GPT-5.2 is sharper on every generation

Same framework, same envs, same seeds — just swap the LLM.



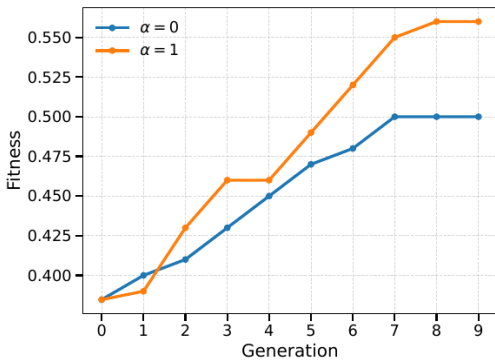
# RESULTS MATCH PPO AND SAC

| Environment      | PPO    | SAC    | CG-FPD | DF-CWP-CP |
|------------------|--------|--------|--------|-----------|
| CartPole         | 500.0  | —      | 500.0  | 500.0     |
| LunarLander      | 246.6  | —      | 241.2  | 260.6     |
| MountainCar      | −128.1 | —      | −105.8 | −108.6    |
| Acrobot          | −63.5  | —      | −90.6  | −78.6     |
| HalfCheetah      | 1579.1 | 4988.5 | 2407.9 | 2103.8    |
| Swimmer          | 95.0   | 87.8   | 247.5  | 219.8     |
| Walker2d         | 3163.2 | 4595.3 | 1603.8 | 1297.6    |
| InvertedPendulum | 1000.0 | 1000.0 | 1000.0 | 1000.0    |

Competitive with hand-designed baselines **across 10 environments**.

Evolved on 5 training envs; remaining 5 are generalization tests.

# ABLATION: DIVERSITY WEIGHT



Levenshtein weight  $\alpha$

- $\alpha = 0$ : no structural regularization  $\Rightarrow 0.50$
- $\alpha = 1$ : full regularization  $\Rightarrow 0.56$
- $\alpha = 0.5$ : **0.65**

Some code-similarity nudge helps;  
too much or too little hurts.

# **DISCUSSION**

Critique and open questions

# STRENGTHS VS. WEAKNESSES

## Strengths

- First **full update-rule** discovery via LLM
- Genuinely novel mechanisms (no value, no PG)
- Clean extension of REvolve's machinery
- LLM-HPO handles fitness fragility cleanly

## Weaknesses

- 30 h per candidate on  $4\times A100$
- Narrow benchmarks (CartPole / MuJoCo only)
- Is GPT-5.2 discovering or remembering?
- Only 2 evolutionary seeds per LLM
- No head-to-head vs. DiscoRL
- Constitutional constraints never ablated

# WHERE THIS PAPER SITS IN THE FIELD

|                  | RL                                                      | Alignment                                            |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| NN-parameterized | DiscoRL<br>(Oh 2025)<br>meta-learned NN                 | RLHF / DPO<br>(Rafailov 2023)<br>neural reward model |
| Code             | <b>This paper</b><br>(Sygkounas 2026)<br>evolved Python | DiscoPOP<br>(Lu 2024)<br>LLM-evolved loss            |

The real contest — **evolved source code** vs. **meta-gradient** for RL.

# OPEN QUESTIONS

- Surrogate fitness to break the 30 h/candidate wall.
- Lift the constraints — let evolution decide whether to re-use actor–critic.
- Scale to Atari and robotics — generalization is still untested.
- Curriculum over environments — connect to POET, XLand.
- Self-improving proposer — EvoTune-style DPO on the evolved database.

Takeaway. REvolve showed LLMs can evolve rewards. This paper shows they can evolve the entire algorithm. The open question is whether what they discover is genuinely new — or just a good remix of what the model already saw.

# THANK YOU!

Questions & Discussion

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